

Misuse Of Social Media

GE — Public Administration · Assignment

Name :- _____

College :- _____

Class :- _____

Year :- _____

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INDEX — Table of Contents

- 01 Introduction to Social Media
- 02 What is Misuse of Social Media?
- 03 Major Types of Social Media Misuse
- 04 Cyberbullying & Trolling
- 05 Fake News & Disinformation
- 06 Privacy Violations & Data Misuse
- 07 Social Media Addiction & Impact on Mental Health
- 08 Case Studies
- 09 Legal Framework in India
- 10 Preventive Measures
- 11 Conclusion & References

Introduction to Social Media

- Digital platforms for creating, sharing, and exchanging information.
- Key Platforms: Facebook, Instagram, Twitter (X), WhatsApp, Telegram, Snapchat, LinkedIn, YouTube, TikTok.
- Over 5.17 billion people use social media worldwide (2025).
- Average daily usage: 2.5 hours per person globally.
- India has 750+ million social media users.
- Transformed communication, business, politics, and governance.
- Acts as a double-edged sword — great benefits, but significant risks.

What is Misuse of Social Media?

- Using platforms in ways that harm individuals or society.
- Cyberbullying & harassment.
- Spreading fake news and disinformation.
- Hate speech & communal posts.
- Identity theft & online fraud.
- Sharing unverified information and forwarding misleading content.
- Oversharing personal data (privacy violations).
- Addictive scrolling behaviour that harms daily life.

Major Types of Social Media Misuse

- Cyberbullying: Using platforms to threaten, intimidate, or humiliate.
- Trolling: Posting inflammatory messages to provoke responses.
- Fake News: Deliberately spreading false or misleading information.
- Privacy Violations: Unauthorized data collection, doxxing, stalking.
- Online Fraud: Phishing, financial fraud, and impersonation.
- Hate Speech: Attacking people based on religion, race, gender, caste.
- Addiction: Excessive use affecting mental health and daily life.
- Defamation: Publishing false statements damaging reputation.

Cyberbullying & Trolling

Key statistics

- 37% of youth globally have experienced cyberbullying.
- 60% of victims do not report it.
- 15% of victims have considered self-harm.

What it looks like

- Threatening messages, embarrassing photos, fake profiles, exclusion from groups.
- Common among teenagers and young adults; Instagram, Snapchat and TikTok are hotspots.
- Can lead to depression, anxiety, and suicidal thoughts.
- Trolling is often anonymous, making accountability difficult.

Fake News & Disinformation

- Deliberately created false content — rumours, morphed photos, edited videos, deepfakes.
- Spreads faster than truth because it is emotional, sensational and shareable.
- WhatsApp forwards are a major carrier in India.
- Fake news about child lifters has triggered mob lynchings (Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Karnataka).
- False health cures and vaccine rumours endanger public health.
- Political misinformation and paid troll armies manipulate elections.

Impact

- Panic, communal tension, violence, and loss of trust in genuine news.

Privacy Violations & Data Misuse

- Doxxing: Publishing private information (address, phone) without consent.
- Stalking: Using location tags and check-ins to track individuals.
- Data Harvesting: Apps collecting user data for ads or selling it to third parties.
- Cambridge Analytica (2018): 87 million Facebook users' data harvested for political profiling.
- Revenge Porn: Sharing intimate images without consent — punishable under the IT Act.
- Deepfakes: AI-generated fake videos used for blackmail and defamation.

Tip

- Review app permissions, use two-factor authentication, and avoid oversharing location data.

Social Media Addiction & Impact on Mental Health

- Endless scrolling design ('infinite feed') keeps users hooked for hours.
- Addiction signs: checking phone first thing in morning, anxiety without phone, sleep loss.
- FOMO (Fear of Missing Out) and social comparison lower self-esteem.
- Linked to anxiety, depression, poor concentration and poor academic performance.
- Blue light and late-night use disturb sleep cycles.
- Cyberbullying victims face higher risk of self-harm and suicidal thoughts.

Way out

- Screen-time limits, digital detox, no-phone hours, and real-world social activity.

Case Studies

- Cambridge Analytica (2018): Facebook data of 87 million users misused to influence elections.
- Mob lynchings in India (2018): Viral fake WhatsApp rumours about child abductors led to deadly mob attacks.
- Blue Whale Challenge (2017): A sinister online 'game' that pushed vulnerable teenagers toward self-harm.
- Deepfake incidents (2023–24): AI-generated fake videos of actors and politicians circulated online.
- Sextortion scams: Fake profiles befriend victims, record private video calls, and blackmail them for money.

Legal Framework in India

- IT Act, 2000 (Amended 2008): Sec 66C (identity theft), Sec 66D (cheating by impersonation), Sec 67 (obscene content).
- IPC / Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita: defamation, promoting enmity (Sec 153A), public mischief (Sec 505).
- POCSO Act, 2012: Protects minors from online sexual abuse.
- IT Rules, 2021: platforms must remove unlawful content and appoint grievance officers.
- DPDP Act, 2023: Regulates processing of personal data by digital platforms.
- Proposed Digital India Act: comprehensive digital governance framework.
- Remedy: report at cybercrime.gov.in or call helpline 1930.

Preventive Measures

For users

- Verify before sharing — check official sources and fact-checkers (Alt News, BOOM, PIB Fact Check).
- Use strong passwords, two-factor authentication and privacy settings.
- Never share OTPs, bank details or intimate images online; block and report abusers.

For parents & schools

- Digital literacy education, open conversations, and screen-time discipline.

For platforms & government

- Fact-check labels, AI-content markers, fast takedowns and cyber-awareness campaigns.

Conclusion & References

Conclusion

- Social media is a powerful tool — its value depends entirely on how we use it.
- Misuse thrives on anonymity, speed and unawareness; awareness and accountability are the antidotes.
- Law must protect victims without suppressing free expression.
- Every user is a gatekeeper: pause, verify, then forward.

References

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